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Unit 4 Assignment

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Part 1: Business Proposal

Proposal for an AI-Powered Customer Support System

Prepared for: Meridian Retail Group

Prepared by: NovaBridge Solutions

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Executive Summary

Meridian Retail Group currently handles a large volume of customer questions through email, website forms, and online chat. As customer activity increases, responding quickly and consistently becomes more difficult. NovaBridge Solutions proposes the implementation of an AI-powered customer support system that can answer common questions, organize incoming requests, and direct complex issues to human representatives.

The proposed system is designed to support employees rather than replace them. It will handle repetitive questions such as order status, return policies, store information, and frequently requested product details. Human employees will remain responsible for sensitive, unusual, or complex cases. This approach can reduce repetitive workload while allowing employees to spend more time on customer problems that require judgment and personal attention.

Background and Business Need

Customer expectations for fast responses have increased as businesses have expanded their digital services. Delayed responses can create frustration and place additional pressure on customer support employees. When employees spend a large portion of their working day answering the same basic questions, less time is available for complicated cases and relationship-building.

Meridian Retail Group therefore has an opportunity to improve its support process by introducing an AI-assisted system. The proposed solution would provide customers with immediate responses to routine questions while creating an organized process for transferring more complicated requests to employees.

Proposed Solution

Nova Bridge Solutions proposes a twelve-week implementation of an AI-powered customer support platform.

During the first two weeks, the project team will review Meridian's current customer support workflow and identify the most frequent types of customer questions. Existing frequently asked questions, policies, product information, and support procedures will then be organized into a controlled knowledge base.

During weeks three through six, the AI assistant will be configured and tested using approved company information. The system will be designed to provide answers only from authorized information and to transfer questions to human representatives when the requested information is unavailable or when human judgment is required.

During weeks seven through nine, the system will enter a controlled pilot phase. A limited group of customers and support employees will use the system while the project team monitors response quality, escalation rates, and customer feedback.

The final three weeks will focus on improvements, employee training, documentation, and preparation for wider deployment.

Benefits

The proposed system can provide several business benefits.

First, it can improve response availability by providing assistance outside normal employee working hours. Customers with simple questions would not necessarily need to wait for a representative.

Second, the system can reduce repetitive work for customer-support employees. Instead of repeatedly answering the same basic questions, employees can focus on complicated cases that require reasoning, empathy, and decision-making.

Third, the system can improve consistency. A centralized knowledge base can help ensure that routine questions receive standardized answers based on approved company policies.

Fourth, the system can generate useful information about common customer concerns. Management can use this information to identify recurring problems and improve products, policies, or website content.

Finally, the proposed system can be expanded gradually. Meridian would not need to automate every customer-support function immediately. The organization could begin with low-risk, repetitive tasks and expand its use after reviewing performance.

Timeline

Period	Major Activity
Weeks 1–2	Workflow analysis and requirements gathering
Weeks 3–6	AI configuration and knowledge based development
Weeks 7–9	Controlled pilot and employee feedback
Weeks 10–11	Testing, improvements, and training
Week 12	Final evaluation and deployment recommendation

Financial Considerations

The estimated initial project cost is $24,500, including system configuration, knowledge-base preparation, testing, employee training, documentation, and initial technical support. An estimated $1,200 per month would be required for ongoing platform maintenance, monitoring, and technical support.

The financial value would depend on the volume of customer inquiries and the amount of employee time redirected from repetitive tasks. For this reason, the pilot phase will measure response time, escalation rates, customer satisfaction, and employee workload before full deployment.

Conclusion

NovaBridge Solutions recommends that Meridian Retail Group begin with a controlled twelve-week implementation rather than immediately deploying AI across all customer-support activities. This approach allows the organization to evaluate measurable results before making a larger investment.

The proposed system combines AI automation with human oversight. By beginning with repetitive and lower-risk customer questions, Meridian can explore the benefits of AI while keeping employees responsible for complex decisions and sensitive customer interactions. The pilot will provide the evidence needed to determine whether broader implementation is appropriate.

Part 2: Report on a Business Trend

The Growing Use of Artificial Intelligence in the Workplace

Executive Summary

Artificial intelligence is becoming an increasingly important part of modern business operations. Organizations are using AI to support communication, data analysis, customer service, software development, research, and other knowledge-based activities. A major development is the increasing interest in AI agents that can perform tasks and support workflows rather than simply respond to individual prompts.

Introduction

The purpose of this report is to examine the growing use of AI in the workplace and identify its main effects on businesses and employees. This trend is important because organizations are increasingly considering AI not only as an individual productivity tool but also as part of broader changes to business processes.

Main Findings

The first major finding is that AI adoption is moving toward more integrated workplace use. Microsoft's 2026 Work Trend Index surveyed 20,000 workers who use AI across 10 countries and examined large-scale Microsoft 365 productivity data. The report describes increasing use of AI agents and emphasizes that organizations need to redesign how people and AI systems work together.

A second finding is that AI is changing the skills businesses need. The World Economic Forum's *Future of Jobs Report 2025*, based on information from more than 1,000 employers, identifies AI and big data as the fastest-growing skills over the 2025–2030 period. It also emphasizes the continuing importance of human capabilities such as analytical thinking, creative thinking, resilience, flexibility, and lifelong learning.

A third finding is that businesses are beginning to consider AI as part of workforce planning. Microsoft's 2025 Work Trend Index found that 81% of surveyed leaders expected agents to be moderately or extensively integrated into their organization's AI strategy within the following 12–18 months. The same research reported that 78% of leaders were considering hiring for new AI-related roles.

Analysis

These findings suggest that workplace AI is developing beyond simple automation. Businesses are increasingly exploring ways for employees and AI systems to work together. However, successful adoption requires more than purchasing AI software. Employees need appropriate training; organizations need clear processes, and human oversight remains important for decisions involving judgment, accuracy, privacy, and accountability.

The growth of AI also means that employees may need to develop both technical and human skills. Technical knowledge can help workers use AI effectively, while communication, analytical thinking, creativity, and adaptability remain important when evaluating AI-generated information and making decisions.

Conclusion

The main finding of this report is that AI is becoming an important business trend that is influencing both workplace processes and skill requirements. Current research indicates growing organizational interest in AI agents, AI-related roles, and workforce upskilling. At the same time, businesses need to combine technological adoption with employee development and appropriate human oversight. Organizations that approach AI as a combination of technology, people, and redesigned workflows can make more informed decisions about how to use it effectively.

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